jacket – might be lucky to make 500m (1,650ft) an hour. Even without enemy action, casualties were sustained from falls, snakebite, heat stroke, and other natural causes. "No-contact" missions were common. When firefights occurred, the Marines inevitably suffered losses to the well-trained, tenacious communist infantry. The availability of helicopters to evacuate the wounded saved many lives, although "medevac" missions were extremely dangerous; low-roving helicopters were prime targets for enemy mortar fire.

UNDER SIEGE

The Marines increasingly found themselves on the defensive as their firebases and outposts just south of the DMZ came under attack from NVA forces. The hill-top base at Con Thien was the object of a determined NVA infantry assault in September 1967. This was beaten off by the Marine garrison, but they then came under sustained artillery bombardment from NVA 130mm and 152mm guns sited inside the DMZ. Marine artillery and aircraft hit back at the artillery and at the NVA soldiers around the base. For the Marines sheltering in bunkers at Con Thien, the experience was reminiscent of World War I trench warfare. Once the monsoon rains started, the base became a quagmire of red mud in which men sank knee-deep. Around the flooded bunkers, artillery fire created a barren moonscape, scorched and pocked with craters. The siege of Con Thien was lifted at the end of October, but it was sign of things to come.

On 21 January 1968, NVA artillery, rocket, and mortar fire struck the Marine base at Khe Sanh in the foothills of the Cordillera. The Marines' ammunition dump exploded, destroying much of their supplies. For the Americans it was an inauspicious start to a siege that was to last for 77 agonizing days. The base was defended by some 6,000 men, mostly

Jungle survival kit
An assortment of medications and preventatives was issued to each Marine. In the absence of kindling, hexamine fuel tablets were used for cooking.



> "THE CORPS – WE LOVE IT AND SHALL DIE FOR IT. IF YOU HAVE NEVER BEEN IN IT, YOU SHALL NEVER UNDERSTAND IT."
>
> **BRAD LEMKE**, US MARINE CORPS GUNNERY SERGEANT



Sea Knight
A CH-46 Sea Knight helicopter arrives at the Marine base of Khe Sanh. The helicopter provided all-weather, day/night transport for troops, equipment, and supplies.